WEST BENGAL/ TMC

The Shake-Up

By Romita Datta

It started with the party organisational election where Trinamool Congress (TMC) chief Mamata Banerjee was re-elected to the chairperson's post. Ten days later, at a hastily convened meeting on February 12, she disbanded the posts of national general secretary held by her nephew and party No. 2 Abhishek Banerjee, abolished sundry other posts and removed their office-bearers and constituted a 20-member 'national working committee'.

As of now, there is no hierarchy in the new committe, which includes herself, Abhishek and a motley crowd of partymen from diverse backgrounds. Among them are political stalwarts such as Yashwant Sinha and Mamata's trusted loyalists like Amit Mitra, Partha Chatterjee, Firhad Hakim and Aroop Biswas besides leaders like party strongman and Birbhum district president Anubrata Mondal. Sources say Mamata will allocate portfolios by the end of February.

Why this hasty re-engineering of the party set-up? Was it the sense that challenging voices were growing louder in the party, questioning her policies, even her authority?

For sure, Abhishek's rise post-election has created a rift. The 2021 Bengal assembly poll result was a watershed in Trinamool's political history—for the first time, it wasn't an all-Mamata show. Two other people also got credit for the victory, poll strategist Prashant Kishor, who ran the election campaign, and Abhishek. The TMC chief acknowledged the latter's role in the victory by making him the TMC national general secretary and vice-president within a month of the results.

Mamata junked the old posts, including nephew Abhishek's, and has put in place a new 20-member working committee

But Abhishek becoming the party's No. 2 came with an attendant set of problems. The heir apparent wanted to do things differently, advocating the need for reforms in the party such as grooming a second rung of leaders, introducing a 'one man, one post' system and setting an age limit for party candidates. Soon, the veterans started feeling insecure and took up positions behind Mamata. Meanwhile, the young brigade was rallying behind Abhishek, making the generational clash noisy and appearing as if it was a rift between the aunt and nephew. None of the new members in the committe are Abhishek loyalists, except maybe Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Sekhar Ray.

As word got around that Abhishek, the Diamond Harbour MP, would step down from the general secretary post to set an example for his one-party, one-post formula (thereby setting a precedent for others, including his aunt), Mamata apparently felt enough was enough. The TMC chief convened the emergency meeting and disbanded all the committees. The present committee is the opposite of all that Abhishek and his youth brigade had been demanding. "The majority are above 65 and also hold multiple posts. And those who are reportedly close to Abhishek have been deliberately dropped. It's a clear sign of take it or leave it," says a senior Trinamool leader, on condition of anonymity. Of course, it's also a committee that ensures a single line of command (read Mamata's).

Not long ago, before the intra-party feud erupted, there was talk that the Trinamool Congress was going for an organisational revamp and that there would be a chairperson and a vice-chairperson. Abhishek was tipped to occupy the latter post. But in his undue haste, he seems to have upset his aunt and the apple cart. ■



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

GROWING RIFT? Mamata Banerjee with nephew Abhishek (in white) after she was re-elected TMC chairperson, Feb. 2